

Appendix 2: Jazz Language

This note does not set out to provide a glossary of jazz terms or jazz slang. Such lists may be found elsewhere, e.g. in Feather's *Encyclopedia*, and are almost always out-of-date by the time they are printed. Rather, it asks how the jazz vocabulary is formed. It consists of three rather different things: (a) technical terms, (b) jive-talk, and (c) names.

Since the founders of jazz were mainly illiterate, at least musically, their technical and critical terminology owes little to orthodoxy except the names of the instruments and of certain elementary musical concepts such as keys and chords. Technical terms either duplicate existing, but unfamiliar, ones—e.g. *slide*, *smear*, for glissando, *slapping* for pizzicato playing, *changes* for the harmonic progression of a tune—or they describe things for which no proper academic equivalent exists, e.g. *shake* (an extreme form of vibrato), *chase* (a series of choruses by two or more players each playing several bars in turn), *breaks* (open passages in the performance when the rhythm is suspended, more generally, solo passages), or *blue notes*. Most of these terms are formed by analogy, except a few of obscure origin, such as *gig* (a casual job, notably a one-night stand) or *riff* (a repeated two- or four-bar phrase). A virtually self-explanatory term from ordinary language is given a specialized meaning; or else a simple metaphor is used, e.g. *dirty* for a kind of instrumental sound. The vocabulary is utilitarian and, until recently, when musicians have begun to use musical jargon, unpretentious. The earlier jazz musicians did not feel the need to call themselves by a socially more respectable name, as undertakers call themselves morticians or press agents public relations experts. Louis Armstrong had his Hot Five, not his Hot Quintet. An orchestra was and is a *band* if large, a *combo* (combination) when small. A melody or theme is (or was) a tune; a composition an *arrangement*, a band's repertoire, its *book*. Its leader is the *front man*, its members *sidemen*. Pretentiousness only began to creep in since the later 1930s when the trios and sextets arrived.

This simple method of forming technical terms will not do for more complex concepts such as musical styles. These cannot be self-explanatory, though *bop*, (*be-bop* or obs. *re-bop*) is said to copy a rhythmic phrase. Mostly the names of jazz styles have been formed in exactly the same way as those of the Lake Poets, the Euston Road School, or the Fauves, i.e. by association: *barrel-house*, *boogie-woogie*, *Dixieland*, *Kansas City*.

The formation of a technical vocabulary for critical appreciation, value-judgments, and other imprecise concepts is even harder. Since the only jazz critics were for long the musicians and the public, neither very articulate in words, the critical vocabulary is simple and adapted from non-musical experience. It has been argued that the terms which express success in playing jazz, or the player's sensation when he thinks he is playing well, or the appreciation of both, are borrowed from the most pleasurable sensations of ordinary life. Sex is an obvious source, as in *jazz* itself (apparently a Delta word for coitus), in *to send* (to induce ecstasy or orgasm, obs. to sweep away the listener), or perhaps in *hot*, which has well-established sexual associations. Drink and drugs are others, their sensations being in some respects more suitable analogues of jazz experience, since they provide continuous exaltation rather than periodic climaxes; not to mention the fact that they can be combined with playing. Perhaps the modern, but uninviting, fashion of using terms taken from mental derangement for praise (*crazy*, *insane*, *nutty*) is merely an extension of the metaphors taken from drugging (*real gone*, *out of this world*). Perhaps it marks the increasing turn of certain schools of jazz from normality, the rise of anti-social jazz. At all events the fashion cannot be traced back beyond the later 1930s.

In a more general sense the terms for emotion were formed by metaphor, e.g. by the widespread practice of equating joy with height ('exaltation') and grief with depth; or with the colours red and blue, or with fast and slow. Thus the quality most desired in the old blues is that it should be *low-down* or *dragging*. (The modern term *funky*—smelly—compares with the orthodox 'earthy'.) On the other hand *hot* and *cool* have the associations, excited and relaxed. Much the most difficult linguistic job is to find words for the two connected but indefinable things, the 'right' mood when the playing goes well, and the rhythm.

Rhythm (and since bands depend on it, the playing of the entire band) is described in terms of two kinds of movement: to-and-fro and forwards. A band *moves* or *drives* or just *goes*; it *swings*, *jumps*, or *rocks*. It moves and stays in one place, which is the essence of good jazz rhythm. The metaphors for the 'right' mood of the band are merely ways of expressing approval: it may be real hot or real cool, depending on style, *solid*, *groovy* (obs. *in the groove*), or merely *right*.

Obviously this critical vocabulary is very feeble and crude, though less so than the modern inarticulateness of the 'fans' for whom criticism is exhausted in a few mumbles: *the greatest*, *the most*, *wild*. This poverty is not only due to the fact that words are not the instrument of jazz musicians, but also to the fact that, being both players and critics, they are merely an ancillary to instrumental demonstration. The following passage by a famous New Orleans drummer sounds vague enough to the layman, but much less so to musicians used to playing in front of drummers:

Each man has a solo, I give him a different beat. It may sound to someone that's listening close by the same, but it's not. I would say it's a different *sound* to it, because I give every man a chance of his opening. In other words, like a guy is going to come in, I give him something for him to come in on, and it makes it different from the fellow that's got through.... Even if it's piano or trumpet or clarinet, I give some kind of indication that something's coming, and *that* a lot of drummers don't do, because you've got to *think*....

(Quoted in *The Jazz Makers*, ed. Shapiro and Hentoff, p. 41.)

The second kind of jazz language, *jive-talk* or hipster-talk is not a technical terminology but an argot or cant designed to set the group apart from outsiders. Its foundation is the distinction between those who are *hip* or 'in', and the *squares* who are not. The player as such calls his instrument a clarinet, which identifies it well enough; *qua* hipster he may call it by some name which only the initiate can understand, e.g. the obs. *gobstick*. In the past most such private argots have relied on a fair amount of isolation, and thus maintained themselves fairly easily. But the hipster

is not set aside from the rest, and since the later 1930s the publicity boys have constantly broadcast his exclusive terms to the world at large, on the perennial advertising theory that exclusiveness can be sold ready-made to the millions. Thanks to the 'swing' craze localized Harlem terms like *jitterbug* became nationally familiar to American teenagers, and internationally familiar enough for the late Neville Chamberlain to commit a memorable howler by using them.* Naturally, therefore, jive-talk protects itself against the seepage of its 'secrets' to the uninitiated by constantly changing, or else by finding expressions so ambiguous, allusive, or untranslatable, as to be beyond the reach of the squares. More than other argots, therefore, jive-talk puts a premium on linguistic creativeness and slipperiness.

It contains all the fancy-dress devices of private languages: rhyming slang (*Jack the Bear* for nowhere), the double disguise (*bread* for dough for money), and the like; the never-ending substitution of new passwords into the group for the old codes (e.g. new names for marihuana—*reefer*, *muggles*, *weed*, *tea*, *grass*, *muta*, *grefa*, *charge*, *gauge*, *hemp*, *hay*, *pot*); the use of neutral and general words for highly specific things (e.g. *on the stuff*, or simply *on* for drug addiction). But it also contained the deliberate use of language as a game, or perhaps (to use the obvious parallel) as a joint and collective improvisation, rather than a simple means of communication. Hence the odd, lilting, rhyming phrases some of which have been made familiar through the rock-and-roll craze, which has had similar effects to the swing craze of the later thirties: 'see you later, alligator, in a while, crocodile', or 'zoot suit'. Hence the peculiar poker-faced phrases which, depending on the situation, may mean the opposite of what they say: 'he's terrible, he plays some awful horn.' Hence, among blacks, the constant, half-defiant, half-self-deprecating, entirely anti-white allusions to and improvisations upon the theme of 'the race' and its internal stratifications. (Cf. the obs. *gate-mouthed*, shortened to *gate*, which used to be a mode of address among earlier hipsters: taken from the loose, half-open mouth of the black lounge.) In the nature of things a glossary of jive-talk is invariably out-of-date and incomplete. The most accessible description of one of its phrases is in Mezzrow and Wolfe's

Really The Blues. The following passages may be quoted, though partly out-of-date and a little coloured up:

FIRST CAT: Hey there, poppa Mezz, is you anywhere?

ME: Man, I'm down with it, stinking like a honky.

F. C.: Lay a trey on me, ole man.

M.: Got to do it, slot. Gun the snatcher on your left raise—the head mixer laid a bundle his ways, he's posin' back like crime sure pays.

F.C.: Father, grab him. I ain't payin' him no rabbit. Jim, this jive you got is a gasser. I'm goin' up to my dommy and dig that new mess Pops laid down for Okey.

Various 'dictionaries' of jive-talk were published between 1938 and 1945, mostly compiled and tricked out by press agents and the like: the *New Cab Calloway Hepster's Dictionary* (N.Y. 1938 and later editions), Dan Burley's *Original Handbook of Harlem Jive* (N.Y. 1944), Louis Shelly's *Hepcat's Jive Talk Dictionary* (Derby, Conn., 1945). Their discrimination and value is uneven. I know of no specific dictionary of hipster slang for the 1950s, perhaps because the jazz fellow-travelling adolescents of the hipster type have reduced their vocabulary to a few dozen painfully imprecise words.

In so far as jive words are not made by analogy or metaphor, or some similar technique, their derivation is often very obscure. It is probably best sought in the specialized argots of the black ghetto, and the borderline zone between entertainment, petty crime, prostitution, drug-pushing, and the like, in which musicians earn their living. How far musicians, as distinct from 'hipsters', use this slang—except for its original purpose of *jiving*, i.e. kidding talk, word-play, and the like—is another question.

*

Two other aspects of jazz language are worth a brief mention: the names of musicians and of pieces of music.

Musicians have two sorts of nicknames, their own and the ones publicity agents give them. Nobody who plays with Louis Armstrong ever calls him *Satchmo* or *Satchelmouth*, a label much fancied for advertising purposes. He is merely called Pops. Musicians' real

nicknames are no more interesting than anybody else's and are almost invariably non-musical: Rabbit (Johnny Hodges), Bubber (Miley), Pres(ident) (Lester Young), Bird or Yardbird (Charlie Parker), Dizzy (Gillespie), Klook (Kenny Clarke), Bean (Coleman Hawkins), and so on. Of the publicity names only one group is really interesting, the *noms-de-guerre* of the old-fashioned blues singers, which have the battered concreteness of the anonymous tramp, or the Homeric grandiloquence of the old-fashioned circus barker and Mississippi boatman. A list of them makes inspiring reading: Pinetop Smith, Cow-Cow Davenport, Montana Taylor, Speckled Red, Cripple Clarence Lofton, Alabama Slim, Arkansas Shorty, Big Maceo, Kansas Joe, Creole Gayno; and in a more splendiferous mood: Easy Papa Johnson, Howlin' Wolf, Lightning Hopkins, Homer the Great, Bat the Humming Bird, Red Hot Shakin' Davis, Devil's Daddy-in-law, Leadbelly, King Solomon Hill. The women can rarely compete with the Black Ivory Kings, Bumble Bee Slims, and Black Spider Dumplings. Normally they merely change their names, though there are a few proper examples of war paint: Big Sister, Cryin' Ellen, the Yas-Yas Girl.

The naming of pieces of music is a specialized activity, halfway between jive-talk and the naming of race horses. There is rarely any particular reason why a piece should bear one name rather than another. On the other hand musicians and others in the business are under constant pressure to find names for an unceasing flow of new numbers. A great many are named by association with places or people: Royal Garden Blues, Mahogany Hall Stomp, Moten Swing (after Benny Moten, a Kansas City band-leader), Sir Charles At Home (after Sir Charles Thompson, pianist, without benefit of honours list). Increasingly musicians have taken to giving such pieces allusive slang names, often obscure to the outsider, sometimes funny, sometimes obscene, sometimes merely sounding good. The modernists, as might be expected, have been particularly drawn to puzzle corner, often inventing meaningless or trick titles: Compulsory, Blue Room, Zec, Illusive, Sombre Intrusion, Bitty Ditty, Chazzanova (all by Thad Jones groups). In recent times a disagreeable tendency towards pretentiousness has also been observable among the *avant-garde*: Purple Heart, Gregorian Chant, Eulogy for Rudy Williams (all by Charlie Mingus). There is really very little to be said

about the principles of inventing jazz titles except that they are increasingly the same as the principles of inventing brand names for products, advertising slogans, or other words and phrases designed to stick in the memory.

* Older readers may recall that he used *jitterbug* for a 'frightened or panicky person', presumably on the analogy of 'jitters'. It merely meant somebody who danced in a particularly active manner or liked to jive in the aisles during a jazz concert.